

MONKEYPOX VIRUS

Alarm Bells Toll

With monkeypox cases surfacing in India, pharma companies are mobilising to prevent an outbreak

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

► **AMID GLOBAL CONCERNS**, India reported its second case of monkeypox (mpox) infection in September. This time it was a 38-year-old man from Kerala's Malappuram district, who recently returned from Dubai. As India addresses rising mpox cases, new business opportunities are emerging for the country's pharmaceutical and diagnostics sectors.

The WHO has recently called on manufacturers of mpox vaccines and diagnostic tools to submit Expressions of Interest for Emergency Use

WORRYING TIMES
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Listing (EUL) due to the escalating situation.

The WHO's Strategic Advisory Group of Experts on Immunisation recommends two vaccines: Jynneos from Denmark and ACAM2000 from the US. In India, Adar Poonawalla, CEO of Serum Institute of India (SII), has advanced efforts to develop a vaccine. "Given the global health emergency, SII is working on a vaccine," says Poonawalla.

The Indian Council of Medical Research and the Department of Health Research have designated AIIMS Nagpur as a Regional Testing Centre for mpox, among 35 laboratories across India designated for testing suspected cases. Some private laboratories are offering tests as well.

Indian companies previously produced mpox vaccines similar to those needed for smallpox, but ceased production in 1979 after the eradication of smallpox in 1977. "Indian companies historically produced smallpox vaccines but no longer do so. If there is interest, companies might consider developing new-generation smallpox vaccines; pharmaceutical companies should evaluate this opportunity," says Dr Naveen Thacker, a member of the Covid-19 expert task force and President of the International Paediatric Association.

On August 14, WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus declared mpox a Public Health Emergency of International Concern. This follows an earlier declaration of the same status in May 2022. On August 18, Prime Minister Narendra Modi also chaired a meeting to review India's readiness.

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The need of the hour is to contain the disease by fast-tracking preventive measures. **BT**

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